

TASK-5: CYBERCRIME

UPI / Online Payment Fraud — Awareness Case Study

The "Wrong Transfer" Trap

In 2022, a Bengaluru-based software engineer lost ₹1.4 lakh after receiving a call from someone claiming to have accidentally transferred money to his UPI account. The caller asked him to "return" the funds immediately. No transfer had actually occurred — but by the time he realised, his money was gone. Similar cases have been widely reported by the Cyber Crime Cell, Bengaluru, and covered by *The Hindu* and *India Today*.

How It Typically Happens

1. The fraudster calls the victim, sounding panicked and apologetic about a supposed wrong transfer.
2. They share a fake UPI screenshot as "proof" — easily fabricated using editing apps.
3. The victim, trying to help, opens their UPI app.
4. The fraudster sends a *collect request* — not a payment — and talks the victim through "approving" it, framing it as a refund action.
5. The victim enters their PIN, authorising an outgoing payment to the fraudster.

Who Is Targeted

First-time UPI users, elderly individuals, and small business owners who receive frequent transfer notifications are most commonly targeted.

Consequences

Victims face immediate financial loss with very little chance of recovery, since UPI transactions are instant and often irreversible. Emotional distress, erosion of digital trust, and in some cases, secondary scams targeting the same victim again are all documented outcomes.

Remember: Receiving money never requires your PIN. If someone asks you to approve a request to "send back" funds — stop. That is the scam.